

Weather-Related and Non-Declared Catastrophe Claims Guide

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Audience: Claims adjusters

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This guide addresses weather-related claims handling outside a formally declared catastrophe event; for a declared CAT event, the Catastrophe Claims Surge Protocol governs instead.

1. Scope

Not every weather event rises to the level of a declared catastrophe under the Catastrophe Claims Surge Protocol. A localized hailstorm, an isolated flooding event, or a single severe-wind incident affecting only a small number of policyholders is handled through the standard adjudication process described in the Claims Adjudication Guidelines, with the weather-specific considerations described in this guide.

2. Coverage Part for Weather Damage

Hail, flood, falling objects (tree limbs), and wind damage to a covered auto are Part C (Other Than Collision) losses, not Part D collision losses, since they do not involve the vehicle striking or being struck by another vehicle or object in the collision sense. This distinction determines which deductible applies and is confirmed before any weather-damage payout is computed.

3. Hail Damage Assessment

Hail damage assessment relies on a documented vehicle inspection, since hail damage severity is not always visible in a policyholder's initial description; the repair estimate follows the same reasonableness review described in the Vendor

and Repair Network Management Guide, Section 3, recognizing that hail repair (paintless dent repair, in many cases) has its own specialized pricing norms distinct from collision repair.

4. Flood Damage and Total Loss Likelihood

A vehicle with flood damage reaching the passenger compartment or engine electronics is frequently a total loss candidate even where exterior damage appears limited, because of the difficulty of confirming complete remediation of water-related electrical and mechanical issues; the Total Loss Valuation Methodology's threshold comparison is applied with particular attention to a qualified inspection rather than an estimate based on visible damage alone.

5. Multiple Weather Claims in a Short Period from the Same Household

Multiple weather-related claims from the same policyholder within a short period are not inherently suspicious — weather events by nature can affect a household's vehicles simultaneously (for example, hail damaging two vehicles parked at the same address on the same night) — and are adjudicated independently on their own facts rather than treated as a fraud indicator under the Fraud Indicators Guide, unless the specific facts otherwise align with a listed indicator.

6. Distinguishing Storm Damage from Pre-Existing Damage

Where a policyholder reports storm damage on a vehicle with any pre-existing, unrelated damage already noted in prior claim history or a prior inspection, the adjuster documents which damage is attributable to the current weather event and which pre-dates it, since only the current event's damage is compensable under this claim.

7. Regional Weather Event Awareness

Where a documented regional weather event (published by the National Weather Service or a similar authority) corresponds to the reported date and location of loss, this corroborating evidence is noted in the claim file and supports, but does not by itself establish, that the specific reported damage resulted from that event — the vehicle-specific inspection in Sections 3 and 4 remains the primary basis for the coverage and payout determination.

8. Escalation to Declared Catastrophe Status

Where a weather event initially handled under this guide is later formally declared a catastrophe (because its scope grows beyond initial assessment), affected open claims are transitioned to the Catastrophe Claims Surge Protocol's procedures going forward, without needing to be re-adjudicated from the beginning if the coverage determination already reached is unaffected by the change in classification.